Individual Assignment Cover Sheet

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1. Introduction

The present document provides an overview in chronological order of the experience my team and I had over the Cambridge Venture Project (CVP) for our MBA programme. Following instructions the name of the client organisation is not included, and my team members are given different names.

Linking the concepts covered during this course in management and the CVP is a great opportunity to put the theory into Praxis (real practice). I take the definition of incident as a particular event during the CVP as an important situation or circumstance that impacted the dynamics of our team while working together, whether could have some friction, confrontation or positive outcomes. There were more than five incidents during the project. The key frameworks applied on the chronological description of the 5 incidents are as follows:

- Project Funnel
- Dealing with different personality types
- Solving conflicts
- Power management
- Handling Difficult Conversations

2. Motivation

The project funnel introduced during this course (Goodall, 2024a) is a good starting point to define the relevant stages of the project. According to the type of personality tests we had at the beginning of Michaelmas term, I was assessed as balance between driver and analytical (Merril, 1977), this is related to the project funnel framework. As expected through the funnel model, I had to modify my approach towards working with my team as different assumptions were proven to be different in practice.

Since an early stage in my career to managed and led multidisciplinary teams, one key constant: “they were economically compensated”, with clear HR and work guidelines. However, the CVP was a different experience; yes, there was a client and professionals supporting us to deliver the project, but as discussed in the upcoming sections the motivation on this project varied significantly for each team member.

3. Cambridge Venture Project and Client Context

The CVP that my team got assigned had the overall objective of assisting a charitable organisation with an operational question that it would be hard for them to answer by themselves. The client mainly focuses on serving the local community under a relevant humanitarian need, under which different ethnic groups would have specific cultural and ideological views. In a general sense, the scenario presented focused on increasing their overall engagement with their local community, not to increase their revenue but instead focused on serving better their local community as expressed by their CEO.

Following the conversations with the client and based on Management Consulting methodologies (Garrette, Phelps and Sibony, 2018), I suggested to define the project using problem tree structures and develop primary and secondary research following that scheme. Primary research was focused on analysing data on reliable public printed material and online. Secondary research focused on conducting interviews with at least 10 professionals in the region with a view on how we could understand and solve the community engagement scenario discussed above.

From first impressions on client and team needs, I got a very particular set of assumptions:

I. Having engaged a worldclass business institution as Cambridge Judge Business School, I understood that the client justification for the project was related to a business need, such as optimising their revenue channels, or donations through their charitable activities. It took us two weeks to validate that this **first assumption** was not the case, and hence mainly it was driven their need to engage with us from a humanitarian point of view, which in turn prevented the project to have specific quantifiable indicators from a business perspective.
II. Considering the overall reputation of Cambridge University and the branding of Judge Business School, I took the **second assumption** that the professional and academic calibre of my peer students, would be very high from a commitment and teamwork point of view. As discussed in the upcoming sections there was a high disparity from a motivational angle for the team to take this project. This, based on a fast assessment I had of my team following a renowned framework (Kahneman, 2011). Overall, my purpose was to provide focus, shared leadership and structure for this project.

The task-group-individual needs model (Goodall, 2024b) introduced in the second lecture of this module, addresses how we should have addressed our needs for the CVP. Those needs will be understood while discussing the next incidents and solutions provided.

4. Incidents

4.1 Incident I. Visiting the client site

On the second week of having started our CVP, we had an appointment at the client site to discuss further their needs, and the context of their organisation. We got a tour of their facilities, discussed the different charitable activities they run for getting funding, and evaluated potential avenues to assist them. We did not speak that day with the CEO, but with a key projects and communications coordinator.

Some of my peers were very quiet up to the point of not asking any question at all, while I was one of the most proactive ones. Nevertheless, it was always my approach to let my peers speak up so they could feel they could participate at any time. The **third assumption** I had was that the team would have common ground to understand the needs of the customer to increase their community engagement.

A second consequence of been a multicultural team was the fact that some of my peers were not familiar at all with that kind of organisation before, since those were not existent in their home countries.

The main outcome of this visit was the realisation from everyone in my team about the level of impact the organisation has at individual life level for those community members who need their services. Under such realisation from the team, I had a **fourth assumption** that they would be very committed to the project, which seemed questionable at the early stages.

How to manage multicultural teams was a common topic for both my team and the client site, aiming to increase community engagement from a multicultural perspective. The approach to manage these teams was presented during the course (Brett, 2006).

4.2 Incident II. Big differences on an event perception

Following the client visit on the way back, I had a candid but respectful conversation with one of the team members: Ian De. Given her passive style of participation and very limited communication, I asked constructively how did she find the visit and whether she wanted to take a different approach on how it went. Overall, she said that it was a quite interesting place, but she felt very shy to participate.

On the other hand, she stated that over the last days she was preparing for a technical job interview as she was so keen to stay in the UK after the MBA. Respectfully, I suggested her, that both for the success of her interviews and for having a more fulfilling experience with the CVP, she needed to speak up more often and not been shy, since that was critical for those outcomes. This was based on a framework to have difficult conversations (Patton, 2019). She appreciated the suggestion stating she need more courage to speak, and asked me for further advice.

A few days after, we had our first session of Management Praxis focused on the CVP and team dynamics. One of the key activities was for each team member to express their individual needs about the CVP and their project. Noticing that everyone from both teams in the session spoke except the team member, I kindly ask her to speak so we could understand her needs. This came with the best intention from my end to let her express her needs despite that other members of the two teams were already moving to another topic. So she was losing her chance to speak up.

I had an informal chat later that evening with Satyajit, another team member, and he person expressed some concerns that I might have put her “on the spot” and potentially it was a bit shameful for her. I managed to address that with the rest of the team but each member had a different point of view. According to recent research on human memory, our mental agents process differently our memories and previous events (Kahneman, 2011). System 1 (fast thinking) was dominant for our team members who thought she was put on the spot. While System 2 (slow thinking) was dominant for me and Ian De, since both took time to assimilate what happened and she was not offended but appreciated the opportunity to express her needs.

4.3 Incident III. They are not paying us to do this…

Despite the cautioning advice of “No asshole behaviour” (Sutton, 2017) at the beginning of this course, there was a negative incident on the second to last week of the project. Satyajit who unfortunately claimed to be the most avid critic of the CVP as a module of the MBA, expressed a shameful statement while been asked to be more involved in the project. Since we could not have our primary research interviews until a very late stage of the project, he kept blaming the client on this slow progress. I stated that it was also our responsibility to check with the client, and provide support or alternatives if they were facing challenges to get the interviews with us confirmed. He replied back, as witnessed by the whole team, stating that he “was not been paid any money for that project” so it was not his problem. In contrast, his main priority during the Michaelmas term was train and dedicate time to his go-kart racing hobby.

Later during the evening Ian De confirmed through our chat that she needed to away the next week given a programming Hackaton, so she was happy to help the team over the weekend. Immediately Satyajit, replied (as evidence recorded in our chat) stating that she should not bother as “no-one was paying us to do this …(offensive word omitted)”. I spoke with Alice my co-lead of the team and explored avenues to keep high the motivation of the team. By following adaption principles on how to handle “difficult” people (Erikson, 2019), we managed to understand better Satyajit personality. By setting a nonjudgemental environment and facilitating respectful discussions (Toegel, 2016) we managed to have more constructive session with Satyajit.

Team conflict was reduced to have a joint session and discuss despite how things were not going as expected, how could we more focus on a final productive week. Acknowledging that Satyajit and Alice had some frictions before, I focused on the impact of previous emotions and ensure we could negotiate a better outcome together (Fisher, 2005).

4.4 Incident IV. Difficult Conversations

The framework from Patton to lead difficult conversations (Patton, 2019), led me to take different perspectives on how to take challenging discussions as 1:1's with my team members. The metaphor of "steering the waters" to create momentum (Greene, 1998a), by constructively confronting some of the team members on the previous week led to good outcomes. Satyajit told me at the end of the project, that he did not like to be confronted, as this was a consequence of human nature to be defensive, so he needed to be approached with more empathy (Greene, 2018). Indeed, he appreciated that as an opportunity to prove to the team that he did not want to give an impression of been lazy and focused on getting the interviews done and build the respective reports.

During the project there were some relative power struggles with my co-lead Alice. All the way till the end of the CVP she clearly had an impulse to direct the team. There were no intentions from my end to let other team members take ownership of leading. However, her listening and oral skills were significantly limited, to a point that there were contradictory instructions from her end or at least that was the impression of the team. I managed to have two conversations with her addressing constructively that real leaders listen and are not reactive towards what others might think of them.

Following the funnel framework, I had two options:

a) either minimise efforts, and see how pressure over the team would lead to some outcomes,
b) I had to adjust my energy and communication style, and humble down to the needs of the team.

Based on a previous Learnings from the corporate world, I focused on the second and use emotional and political intelligence to negotiate a better working scheme. Moreover, I applied Law 7 of Power "Soften People's Resistance by Confirming Their Self-Opinion: The Law of Defensiveness" (Greene, 2018b). Conscious of Alice's interests on applying on Management Consulting roles, I asked her if she thought whether she would face similar power related situations in those roles? She agreed and saw the team dynamics as an opportunity to be better prepared for upcoming interviews and opportunities. The priority for both of us as co-leads was to get the project done and reduce the number of confrontations with our less constructive team member.

4.5 Incident V. Taking Ownership

Observing clear lack of structure and motivation from the team, I decided to follow a set of relevant principles stated by an inspiring Navy Seal Jocko Willink (Willink, 2015). Noticing that Steven and Chei Lin were not engaged during different stages of the project, I created project management framework using Trello and Gantt Charts for them to identify how could they contribute better and according to their skills and values so they could be further motivated (Fitzgerald, 2024).

Andy Grove, the famous former CEO of Intel, introduced Objectives and Key Results (OKRs) in that company (Tedlow, 2007). He is one of my favourite references on modern management as he transformed Intel into a technology giant.

According to Eric Schmidt the former CEO of Google, transparent public communication of aggressive but achievable OKRs, led the organisation to reach great cohesion and effectiveness (Schmidt, 2014). The Nuna Story for OKRs in Health Care (Doerr 2018) is a very inspiring case of team alignment with ambitious objectives in a humanitarian sector. This was related to our CVP and we manged to set similar OKRs for community engagement, outcomes by stakeholders and reaching to critical experts in the field who could help us in our secondary research.

Another important contribution from Andy Grove at Intel was conflict resolution based on “Disagree and Commit” (Tedlow, R. 2007). By following his principles on letting everyone express their opinions but also propose a solution, we managed to put our team together. In our team the sense of ownership was accompanied with more freedom to have purpose and autonomy to run the interviews, which in turn led to further engagement with prosocial purpose (Burkus, 2023). We exceeded our OKR of 10 interviews and instead we ran 15 in a record time (less than 7 days).

5. Final presentation

Our client became quite satisfied with the work we delivered and in the words of our mentor we got outstanding results, based on the primary and secondary research we delivered. The Client got back to us asking for additional content to share, and appreciated we brought light on how they could better engage with their community by:

- creating joint programmes with health organisations,
- work with community and ethnic group champions to recommend their services
- have more inclusive hiring practices,
- have a more analytical approach to quantify the outcomes of their initiatives.

6. Overall Reflection

Learning the right behaviours to know what my team really wanted (Owen, 2018) led me to increase my emotional quotient and discuss my learnings with a leading Professors at Judge Business School and Lecturer of our course. Based on previous sessions it was clearly a dysfunctional team during most of the project as discussed during our CVP focused Management Praxis sessions. We both agree that I did adjust my approach on communicating and leading the team differently. During that session, I referred on how I did adjust to the needs of my team and how I was presenting myself during the joint sessions we have together.

By focusing on the behaviour of the team, I adjusted my approach based on self-awareness and asking feedback (Toegel and Barsoux, 2012) from team members and from my Lecturer. Then with the right changes, I increased persuasiveness within a

group following “big small changes” (Martin, 2014) on communication and participation. The outcomes we got as a team led to more fulfilling experience at the end of the CVP with stronger motivation and purpose (Kwik, 2020) based on the feedback we got from the client.

7. Conclusion

Porter introduced a good approach towards first focusing on one-self to then identify the gaps in the team to manage (Porter, 2019). That led me to change the overall strategy. One of the main situations I had the opportunity to assess about my team, was that we were a multicultural team, and we had different approaches to ask questions. The approach consisted of adapting and using different types of interventions (Brett, Behfar, and Kern, 2006) as summarised in the previous sections.

The paradox of excellence (Delong, 2011) is a great way to understand the context of how some of those incidents were perceived by myself as not particularly positive but in the long run, these were opportunities as well. The funnel model allowed me to see the CVP as a learning process to better validate assumptions, test them twice if necessary and focus to deliver according to the needs of my team and how I could contribute better to the team dynamics and pivot towards more productive working schemes (Tamaseb, 2021). Finally, by understanding my needs and my peers’ we had an overall better working dynamic. Their needs were to learn at a different pace and make the project as efficient as possible while still making a good contribution. In my case I needed to be a more flexible and understanding team member, consequently, I could fulfil an inner call (Greene, 2012) to be a better leader engaged in humanitarian projects.

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